

August 20, 2026

Ambetter from Absolute Total Care
Provider Appeals Department

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Jonathan Hermiston (MRN MUSC4336515), Claim MUSC-5214-1

Patient	Jonathan Hermiston (DOB 1947-12-06)
MRN	MUSC4336515
Member ID / Group	AMB759343522 / GRP-17967
Claim number	MUSC-5214-1
Date of service	2026-06-16
Procedure billed	CPT 99223 — Initial hospital care, high complexity
Primary diagnosis	R69 — Illness, unspecified
Denied amount	\$4,860.97
Denial code	CARC 204 / RARC N130 — This service/equipment/drug is not covered under the patient's current benefit plan.
Appeal deadline	2026-10-15

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health University Medical Center is submitting this formal appeal on behalf of patient Jonathan Hermiston (MRN: MUSC4336515, Member ID: AMB759343522) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-5214-1 for services rendered on June 16, 2026. Ambetter from Absolute Total Care denied the claim in full, citing CARC 204 ("This service/equipment/drug is not covered under the patient's current benefit plan") and RARC N130 ("Consult plan benefit documents/guidelines for information about restrictions for this service"), with the payer remark stating: "Service is excluded under the member's plan benefit document." The total denied amount is \$4,860.97. MUSC Health respectfully contends that this denial is inconsistent with the nature of the service provided, the patient's documented clinical condition, and applicable coverage obligations under the Ambetter from Absolute Total Care Open Access plan, which carries an active coverage period through December 31, 2026.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Mr. Hermiston is a 78-year-old male with a complex, active medical history that includes Alzheimer's disease (onset October 2020), chronic obstructive bronchitis, hypertension, anemia, osteoarthritis of the knee, recurrent urinary tract infection, prediabetes, and a history of drug overdose. His Alzheimer's disease is actively managed with Galantamine 4 MG Oral Tablet, initiated in October 2020. His chronic obstructive bronchitis has been managed long-term with a fluticasone propionate/salmeterol combination inhaler, and he has undergone serial pulmonary rehabilitation and spirometry evaluations as recently as October 2020. The cumulative burden of these active, chronic conditions — particularly Alzheimer's disease in a 78-year-old patient — establishes a clear clinical basis for inpatient evaluation and management at the high-complexity level. The June 16, 2026 admission was billed under CPT 99223, initial hospital care at the highest level of medical decision-making complexity, rendered by Dr. Sarah E. Whitmore, MD (NPI 1447382910) at MUSC Health University Medical Center, an inpatient facility (Place of Service 21).

BASIS FOR APPEAL

The denial characterizes CPT 99223 as a non-covered or excluded service under Mr. Hermiston's benefit plan. This determination appears to be in error. CPT 99223 represents initial inpatient evaluation and management — a foundational category of physician services that is broadly covered under virtually all commercial and Marketplace health plans, including those offered under the Affordable Care Act. Marketplace plans are required to cover essential health benefits, which include hospitalization and physician services. A blanket exclusion of an initial inpatient hospital care code for a 78-year-old patient with active Alzheimer's disease and multiple serious comorbidities would be inconsistent with these coverage requirements. Furthermore, the plan's own allowed amount of \$2,296.60 was calculated for this claim, which strongly suggests the service was recognized as a covered benefit at the adjudication level — making the simultaneous application of a non-covered denial internally contradictory. If the denial was triggered by a coding concern, MUSC Health notes that the primary diagnosis submitted, R69 (Illness, unspecified), may warrant review; however, the patient's documented active condition of Alzheimer's disease supports medical necessity for high-complexity inpatient care, and any coding discrepancy should result in a request for additional information rather than an outright non-covered denial.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Ambetter from Absolute Total Care conduct a thorough review of this denial, reconcile the internally inconsistent application of a non-covered determination alongside a calculated allowed amount, and reprocess Claim MUSC-5214-1 for payment at the contracted rate. If the plan requires additional clinical documentation to support medical necessity or to clarify the primary diagnosis, MUSC Health will provide that documentation promptly upon request. This appeal is submitted in advance of the October 15, 2026 deadline through the secure provider portal as directed.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record